GQ

By Sharon Whitney

INTRODUCTION

PENN: Society seems to think that females have a harder time than males preparing for a date.

QUINN: We're here to counter that widespread belief.

PENN: Men are just as worried about what to wear,

QUINN: what to say

PENN: what to order

QUINN: how to act

PENN: as the ladies are.

QUINN: I mean, we can't all be Mr.

BOTH: "GQ" by Sharon Whitney

PENN: *(Trying on clothes while QUINN lounges in a chair)* So, OK. The red scarf. Do you think she'll like me in red?

QUINN: Red is, well ... red. Maybe it'll get her excited.

PENN: I thought the line, you know... See how it hangs from my neck? The eye kind of travels, huh? Do you think I look taller?

QUINN: I don't know, it's risky.

PENN: Yeah?

QUINN: A little bit much... for you.

PENN: Yeah?

QUINN: Now don't get hurt feelings. It makes your waist look even thicker.

PENN: *Thicker.*

QUINN: You asked.

PENN: Oh, God. The other day I heard her say, "Look at that guy-what a pear." Oh, God.

QUINN: Listen... open up your neckline. That's what I do. A nice deep V, with something

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

gold. Show some hair.

PENN: That's so Mafia ... isn't it? What do you think? Could I get away with it?

QUINN: Hey, you want her to look at your gut?

PENN: *(Pause)* She could look at my jacket. *(He takes a jacket from a garment bag.)* I just bought it. It was in *GQ*.

QUINN: *GQ?*

PENN: I spent a week's pay on it.

QUINN: Huh... You saw it in *GQ?*

PENN: You don't like it. *(QUINN is silent.)* I thought I'd wear it with black slacks and a cream-colored shirt.

QUINN: Cream?

PENN: I thought the guy in the ad kind of looked like me. *(QUINN raises his eyebrows.)* *Jeeze.*

QUINN: *You asked.*

PENN: Sorry. *(Quinn sighs.)* I'm just touchy today. For breakfast, I had two chocolate croissants. I inhaled 'em. *(QUINN clucks.)* Nerves.

QUINN: Oh, forget it. Why deprive yourself because she's got a thing for Greek gods? *(PENN mews like a lost cat.)* You're a little plump, a little soft around the edges. So what?

PENN: *(He whimpers. Long pause)* So. I spend three hundred dollars on a jacket and you say I look like a plate of mashed potatoes.

QUINN: You're overreacting.

PENN: It's the chocolate.

QUINN: *(Rising)* I don't need this.

PENN: I'm sorry, I'm sorry. Stay with me, buddy. Please. Tell me. Please. What's wrong with the jacket?

QUINN: Well. You need me. OK. The cut is English. It's made for someone who can

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

project a kind of "hounds to the foxes" aura. *(Penn mews.)* And the tweed. On you, it's like an extension of your face. It looks like black and white whiskers.

PENN: Hurrah. The Hairy Ape. Three hundred bucks.

QUINN: Maybe... somehow... you can get around it. Try a blue shirt, or even mauve. If you can kill the effect of the tweed... get it away from your skin ...

PENN: I thought I should show my skin, my hairy chest.

QUINN: I was wrong. *(Pause)* Have you ever been draped?

PENN: I'm a winter. Black and white.

QUINN: Oh.

PENN: I'm gong to call her. I'll cancel.

QUINN: Oh, no, no, no. Let's work on this. Build you up.

PENN: I don't even know what to talk about.

QUINN: Ask her about her job. Women like that. It's all they think about, anyway. Their identity depends on it.

PENN: I know all about her job. I work in the same office.

QUINN: Some common sense, please. Play dumb. Let her run her trip. You don't have to listen, just keep eye contact and remember to say "oh" and "uh huh."

PENN: Won't she think I'm slow?

QUINN: She'll never notice. Women love to talk about themselves. It makes them think they got the world under control.

PENN: I read somewhere I should lean across the table and let her sit back. It's very flattering.

QUINN: *(Nodding)* Eat everything on your plate, too. It makes them upset when you order something and tinker with it.

PENN: *OK.*

QUINN: Offer to share something, though. That's sexy. Put something small on your fork and offer it with a line like, "This is superb. Will you sample?"

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PENN: Superb? A fork full of peas?

QUINN: Peas?

PENN: Roast beef? *(QUINN looks like he's been poisoned.)* No?

QUINN: No. For you a sensitive dish. *(PENN is clearly stymied. Beat)* Linguine with white clam sauce.

PENN: Clams give me hives. How about lasagna?

QUINN: Sure. slop it on your tie. *(PENN is lost. Beat)* A green salad with nasturtiums and radicchio. Scallops. Barely warm.

PENN: How about lamb chops? Itsy bitsy ones.

QUINN: In panties.

PENN: Right. Lamb with pants.

QUINN: What are you doing after dinner?

PENN: I could ask her to see my apartment.

QUINN: Oh, I don't know...

PENN: I could make her an espresso. I got some little cups and one of those knives that cuts lemon peel. Should I ask her? I know, I'll just trust my intuition.

QUINN: That's a myth - about men's intuition.

PENN: Yeah?

QUINN: Some have it, but most don't. *(PENN groans.)* All right, if you must: get her to take you to her place. If it's a disaster, you can always go home.

PENN: What if she puts some moves on me?

QUINN: What kind of underwear have you got?

PENN: The best. A hundred percent cotton.

QUINN: White, right?

PENN: You can bleach it.

QUINN: Lord... *(Sighs.)* Calvin Klein has a new silk line. Why don't you go wild and buy a pair of briefs.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PENN: She won't get the wrong idea?

QUINN: They're for heterosexuals. You can tell. They come in royal blue, banker gray and legal pad yellow.

PENN: I'm good in yellow... at least, I used to be.

QUINN: Then you're set. *(PENN gathers his things, prepares to leave, then freezes, stricken.)* What? What... ? What...

PENN: I don't know how to walk.

QUINN: Let's see. *(Head down, arms bowed, fingers curled under, PENN skulks across the stage. QUINN considers him.)* Does "miser's hump" run in your family? *(PENN mews.)* Come on, sport, chest out, chin up ... hup, hup ... not so stiff ... try to look carefree, maybe that would suit you. *(PENN is boggled, but he tries walking this way and that.)* By the way, no beer. Stick with white wine in case you spill it. Or maybe a blush, that's classy. But now that I think about it, it's not you. Do ale.

PENN: Someone should write a book: "What Every Man Should Know."

QUINN: Hmmm. Not a bad idea.

PENN: I'm reading "My Father, My Self."

QUINN: The son's search for identity?

PENN: It really gets me. I cried for half an hour.

QUINN: My shrink says it's no good.

PENN: Oh. *(Beat)* I'm going to call her. I'll cancel.

QUINN: You gonna waste my good advice? *(PENN mews.)* Hang in there.

PENN: Will you meet me for breakfast? I'll have to debrief.

QUINN: Leave a message on my machine.

PENN: I feel so vulnerable.

QUINN: Uh-huh.

PENN: Thanks for everything.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

QUINN: Hey buddy. Walk tall. *(PENN exits. QUINN sits a moment, then rises, calling Off-stage.)* Clerk... ? Sir... ? Excuse me, sir... Yes, ha, ha - ha, ha. Oh, no, I wasn't shouting. Sir, could I possibly... uh, do you suppose... uh, you know that black and white jacket that was in *GQ?* The tweed? Is there a chance I could try it on? ... Oh, any size - whatever size you got... I know it's not really me ... but it could be ... Don't you think?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sharon Whitney
Book: More One-Act Plays for Acting Students
ISBN: 1566080878
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date (Month/Year): July 2003

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY